Pakistan has been inherently and consistently antagonistic towards India over a host of issues. Prime amongst them is that Pakistan has not been able to reconcile itself to the fact that the predominantly Muslim state of Jammu and Kashmir acceded to India in October 1947. We have had four wars over Kashmir; a war by proxy is still continuing; and our bilateral relations have become hostage to this issue. There was frequent cross-border shelling, sniping and skirmishes at the LoC till 2003, when both countries decided to have a ceasefire that is still holding. Pakistan has hopefully realized that it cannot take Kashmir by force. However, after 9/11, things changed drastically for Pakistan. It had to decide whether to go with the Taliban or join the US in the global war on terror. Pakistan chose the latter option but did a partial U-turn in its relations with the Taliban and jehadi organizations that had proliferated in the tribal border areas. They did not take any action against certain terrorist networks whom they classify as strategic assets, like the Haqqani faction. The spillover of the messy situation in Afghanistan has also been adversely affecting the stability and progress of Pakistan.

While dealing with internal turmoil and taking action against the Al Qaida and other terrorist organizations on its border with Afghanistan in areas like Swat and South Waziristan, Pakistan has simultaneously continued to upgrade its conventional and strategic capability. It is building its nuclear arsenal, honing the delivery systems and testing its long-range nuclear-capable missiles. It seeks to achieve conventional parity with us and accordingly has enhanced its defence spending to unaffordable levels. This is definitely at the cost of development.

Who is in control in Pakistan? Going as per media reports and books written by some well-known authors, including some from Pakistan, their army is all-powerful. Some have gone to the extent of saying that while other states have an army, in Pakistan the army has a state. Though on the face of it there is a democratically elected government in place, it is an unstated fact that the army calls the shots. This is particularly so when it comes to dialogue with India over Kashmir or other substantive and sensitive matters.